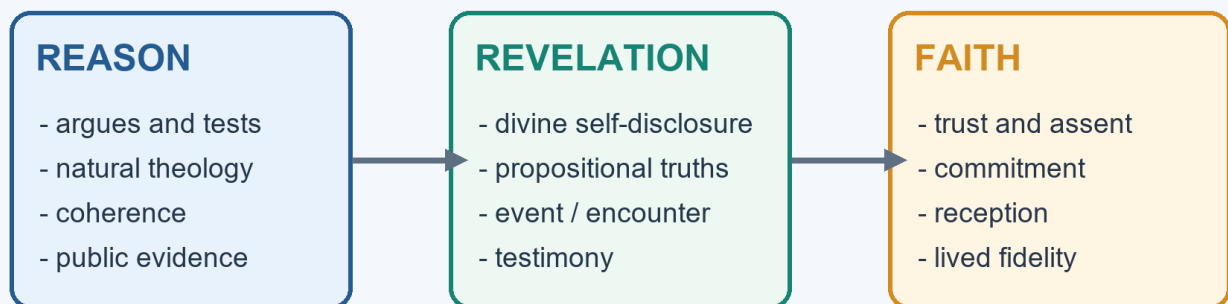


Reason, Revelation and Faith

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

REASON - REVELATION - FAITH



Exam synthesis

Reason is regulative, revelation supplies alleged content, and faith receives it.

No element is rationally adequate when isolated from the other two.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Reason, Revelation and Faith - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its key. Correct options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D across all forty-eight diagnostics.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 40

1. Which statement best captures reason as a regulative rather than constitutive force in religion?

A. It constrains incoherence and tests evidence without necessarily generating revealed content. B. It deduces every religious mystery from self-evident premises. C. It is relevant only after a doctrine has been accepted as infallible. D. It converts faith into demonstrative knowledge.

Answer: A.

Reason is regulative when it vetoes contradiction, disciplines interpretation and assesses testimony. It is constitutive only if it independently supplies the distinctive content of belief, which the balanced account denies.

2. For Aquinas, faith is most accurately described as:

A. An emotional state wholly independent of intellect. B. An act of intellect assenting to divine truth under the command of will moved by grace. C. A probable opinion accompanied by fear that the opposite may be true. D. Demonstrative knowledge of mysteries from natural premises.

Answer: B.

Aquinas makes faith intellectual, volitional and grace-enabled. It has firm assent without the demonstrative vision characteristic of knowledge.

3. Which distinction most precisely separates belief from faith?

A. Belief is communal, whereas faith is always private. B. Belief concerns the unseen, whereas faith concerns only observable conduct. C. Belief is primarily assent that a proposition is true; faith adds trustful entrusting to an ultimate object. D. Belief can be false, whereas faith cannot fail.

Answer: C.

Faith contains beliefs but is not exhausted by them. Its distinctive element is fiduciary commitment - believing *in* rather than merely believing *that*.

4. Under a propositional view of revelation, revelation primarily consists in:

A. A community's ethical transformation without truth-claims. B. A private feeling that cannot be expressed conceptually. C. Historical events whose meaning is created entirely by later interpreters. D. Divinely authorised truths communicated for assent and doctrinal articulation.

Answer: D.

The propositional model treats revealed content as truth-bearing statements mediated through prophets, scripture or tradition. This grounds revealed theology.

5. Hick's non-propositional view is best expressed by which sequence?

A. Divine action or encounter -> faith's experiencing-as -> communal interpretation -> doctrine. B. Doctrine -> deductive proof -> divine action -> private emotion. C. Natural theology -> scientific confirmation -> infallible scripture -> faith. D. Linguistic analysis -> elimination of experience -> revealed propositions.

Answer: A.

For Hick, revelation is primarily divine self-disclosure in events or encounter. Propositions are human, concept-laden interpretations of that disclosure.

6. Natural theology differs from philosophy of religion because natural theology:

A. Rejects all reasoning about God. B. Argues from publicly accessible premises toward theological conclusions. C. Begins only with propositions accepted as revealed. D. Is confined to analysing religious language without evaluating truth.

Answer: B.

Natural theology uses unaided reason to infer conclusions such as God's existence or attributes. Philosophy of religion has a wider analytical field including language, experience and warrant.

7. Which claim properly belongs to revealed theology rather than natural theology in Aquinas' scheme?

A. Every contingent being requires an explanation. B. Order in nature may support an inference to intelligence. C. Trinity is known through divine disclosure rather than demonstrated from natural premises. D. Contradictions cannot both be true.

Answer: C.

Aquinas' mysteries exceed the reach of natural demonstration while not contradicting reason. Natural theology concerns preambles accessible to unaided reason.

8. What is the most accurate relation between Aquinas' "preambles" and "mysteries"?

A. Both are demonstrated by reason, but mysteries require more premises. B. Preambles are irrational, while mysteries are probable. C. Mysteries replace any need for rational argument. D. Reason can establish preambles; revelation supplies mysteries that exceed but do not contradict reason.

Answer: D.

The two-storey structure assigns distinct but harmonious roles. Genuine reason and genuine revelation cannot conflict because truth is ultimately one.

9. Kierkegaardian faith is primarily:

A. Passionate subjective commitment amid objective uncertainty. B. Inference from design to a probable designer. C. Acceptance of only what is publicly verifiable. D. Suspension of every ethical and logical criterion in ordinary life.

Answer: A.

Kierkegaard stresses existential appropriation and risk. His position should not be reduced to casual irrationalism, although the Abraham example creates a serious ethical problem.

10. Which classification best handles the phrase "rational and irrational aspects of faith"?

A. Rational faith versus irrational religion, with no middle category. B. Rationally grounded faith, supra-rational commitment beyond proof, and irrational assent against reason. C. Scientific truth, theological falsehood and moral neutrality. D. Knowledge, perception and inference as equivalent forms of faith.

Answer: B.

The supra-rational category is decisive. Going beyond coercive proof is not the same as contradicting evidence, logic or morality.

11. The Augustinian-Anselmian formula "faith seeking understanding" implies that:

A. Understanding must be completed before faith begins. B. Faith renders rational inquiry impious. C. Faith can initiate an inquiry that reason subsequently clarifies and deepens. D. Faith and reason concern wholly non-overlapping realities.

Answer: C.

The formula avoids both rationalism and fideism. Priority of faith does not eliminate the intellectual task of understanding.

12. Clifford's ethics of belief most directly maintains that:

A. Faith is justified whenever it produces consolation. B. Only religious beliefs require evidence. C. A forced option must always be decided by passion. D. Assent should be proportioned to evidence, and irresponsible believing can be morally blameworthy.

Answer: D.

Clifford's shipowner example shows that negligent belief-formation can harm others. His standard is general, not a special hostility directed only at religion.

13. William James permits passional commitment only when an option is:

A. Living, forced and momentous, with evidence genuinely inconclusive. B. Doctrinally orthodox, socially approved and scientifically proved. C. Privately attractive, easily reversible and evidentially refuted. D. Miraculous, scriptural and institutionally certified.

Answer: A.

James's argument is tightly restricted. It permits choice when postponement itself loses a genuine possibility; it does not authorise belief against decisive evidence.

14. Plantinga's claim that belief in God may be properly basic means that it:

A. Is a self-evident proposition known by conceptual analysis. B. May be rationally grounded without being inferred from other beliefs, while remaining defeasible. C. Is exempt from the problem of evil and religious diversity. D. Is justified simply because a religious community accepts it.

Answer: B.

Proper basicity is not self-evidence or immunity. The belief must be appropriately grounded and responsive to potential defeaters.

15. The Great Pumpkin objection challenges Reformed epistemology by asking:

A. Whether natural theology can establish God's attributes. B. Whether revelation must be propositional. C. Whether permitting theistic belief as basic also permits arbitrary fantasies as basic. D. Whether faith necessarily produces moral conduct.

Answer: C.

The objection targets uncontrolled basicity. Plantinga replies through appropriate grounds, proper function and defeater-sensitivity, though rival well-formed traditions keep the challenge alive.

16. Alston's appeal to doxastic practices argues that:

A. Religious experience is infallible because it is private. B. Sense perception is justified by a non-circular proof unavailable to religion. C. Every established social practice produces knowledge. D. Religious practice may be rationally engaged in absent defeaters, since even perception cannot be validated wholly without epistemic circularity.

Answer: D.

Alston does not equate all practices or promise certainty. He argues for parity in practical rationality between established perceptual and religious practices.

17. Which Indian doctrine is the closest stated analogue of proper basicity?

A. Mīmāṃsā *svataḥ-prāmāṇya*: cognition has intrinsic validity until defeated. B. Nyāya *parataḥ-prāmāṇya*: validity requires external certification. C. Cārvāka restriction of knowledge to perception. D. Buddhist rejection of a permanent self.

Answer: A.

Intrinsic validity resembles the idea that a cognition need not first be inferred from further evidence to be rational. The analogy is structural, not an identity of doctrines.

18. Which Indian doctrine is the closest stated analogue of evidentialism?

A. Advaita's *nididhyāsana*. B. Nyāya *parataḥ-prāmāṇya*, according to which validity is established through something further. C. Mīmāṃsā *apauruṣeyatva*. D. The *Gītā* classification of *śraddhā*.

Answer: B.

Extrinsic certification parallels the demand that a belief's rational standing depend on supporting grounds. Mīmāṃsā's intrinsic validity supplies the contrasting pole.

19. Why must Mīmāṃsā's account of the Veda not be equated straightforwardly with creator-centred revelation?

A. Mīmāṃsā accepts perception as the only *pramāṇa*. B. Mīmāṃsā regards scripture as a modern historical composition. C. The Veda is *apauruṣeya* - authorless, neither human nor the speech of a creator God. D. Mīmāṃsā denies that testimony can disclose supersensible dharma.

Answer: C.

Mīmāṃsā grants Vedic testimony independent authority precisely without a divine speaker. It is a valuable comparison because it separates disclosure from personal divine dictation.

20. Which account best relates śraddhā or saddhā to verification?

A. It is assent that permanently replaces inquiry. B. It is identical with demonstrative knowledge. C. It is valid only when inherited from an institution. D. It is disciplined or provisional trust that enables inquiry and practice directed toward realisation or testing.

Answer: D.

Advaita joins *śraddhā* with *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*, and Buddhist *saddhā* is verification-directed. Trust opens inquiry rather than abolishing it.

21. In Barbour's conflict model:

A. Science and religion make incompatible claims about the same reality, so one must yield where they genuinely overlap. B. Science handles facts and religion handles values without any possible contact. C. Both fields exchange metaphors while withholding truth-claims. D. Theology is systematically reconstructed through current science.

Answer: A.

Conflict occurs when claims occupy the same empirical or metaphysical territory. Scientific materialism and scriptural literalism are mirror-image forms.

22. The principal cost of Gould's NOMA is that it:

A. Turns every religious claim into a scientific hypothesis. B. Purchases peace by sharply separating magisteria and limiting substantive mutual criticism. C. Makes scientific knowledge depend on revelation. D. Commits religion to process metaphysics.

Answer: B.

NOMA is an independence model. Its boundary may be too strict because many religious and scientific claims have ethical, historical or cosmological implications that touch.

23. Barbour's dialogue model is distinguished by:

A. Scriptural literalism about natural history. B. The claim that science and religion never share methods or questions. C. Engagement over boundary questions and methodological parallels without claiming a complete synthesis. D. Reduction of religion to evolutionary psychology.

Answer: C.

Dialogue explores intelligibility, fine-tuning, models, metaphors and theory-ladenness. It opens conversation but does not by itself establish theological conclusions.

24. Which is the characteristic risk of Barbour's integration model?

A. It makes every religious claim non-cognitive. B. It refuses all interaction between theology and science. C. It excludes natural theology and process thought. D. It may make theology hostage to provisional scientific theories.

Answer: D.

Integration offers substantive synthesis through natural theology, theology of nature or process thought. Its depth is also its vulnerability when scientific models change.

25. What is the safest assessment of the Draper-White "warfare thesis"?

A. It is a nineteenth-century conflict narrative now rejected by most historians as an oversimplification. B. It is Barbour's preferred contemporary model. C. It proves that religion has never aided scientific inquiry. D. It is identical

with Gould's NOMA.

Answer: A.

The thesis exists in identifiable nineteenth-century works but should be cited critically. A Galileo-only narrative is inadequate for the broader philosophical relation.

26. John Haught's alternative fourfold map is:

A. Proof, prophecy, practice and prayer. B. Conflict, contrast, contact and confirmation. C. Perception, inference, comparison and testimony. D. Rational, empirical, mystical and sceptical.

Answer: B.

Haught's scheme parallels Barbour while "confirmation" adds the claim that religion may support the intelligibility presupposed by science.

27. Hume's central conclusion in "Of Miracles" is best stated as:

A. Miracles are logically self-contradictory. B. Divine action is metaphysically impossible. C. Miracle testimony faces an exceptionally heavy evidential burden and ordinarily fails to overcome contrary evidence. D. Every unusual event falsifies a law of nature.

Answer: C.

Hume's argument concerns evidential warrant, not a demonstration of metaphysical impossibility. This distinction is a standard UPSC trap.

28. Hume's maxim about testimony and miracles says, in substance, that testimony suffices only if:

A. The witness belongs to the claimant's religious community. B. The event has great moral consequences. C. No scientific explanation has yet been proposed. D. The falsehood of the testimony would be more miraculous than the event reported.

Answer: D.

Hume asks the evaluator to balance the improbability of the miracle against the improbability of testimonial error, then accept the lesser marvel.

29. Swinburne's "non-repeatable counter-instance" formulation primarily challenges:

A. Hume's definition of a miracle as a violation of a law of nature. B. James's account of genuine options. C. Aquinas' distinction between preambles and mysteries. D. Plantinga's account of warrant.

Answer: A.

If laws are exceptionless regularities, calling a miracle a violation may define it out of existence. Swinburne permits an exceptional event against an otherwise well-confirmed law.

30. Earman's Bayesian criticism of Hume maintains that:

A. Prior probability is irrelevant to rational belief. B. Sufficient independent testimony can raise the posterior probability of an initially improbable event. C. All witnesses have equal reliability. D. A miracle is true whenever several people report it.

Answer: B.

Bayesian reasoning distinguishes low prior probability from probability after evidence. It does not guarantee miracles; it rejects an in-principle ban on testimonial accumulation.

31. Hume's "contrary miracles" argument holds that:

A. A natural law is contradicted whenever a witness lies. B. Miracles within one religion always support identical doctrines. C. Miracles offered for incompatible religions undermine one another's testimonial force. D. Religious diversity makes all testimony epistemically worthless.

Answer: C.

The argument targets mutually incompatible authentication claims. Critics reply that cancellation is not automatic if traditions' claims overlap or if each report is assessed independently.

32. Which Indian comparison most strongly contrasts with Western miracle-based apologetics?

A. Nyāya makes miracles the only proof of Īśvara. B. Advaita treats every *siddhi* as liberation. C. Mīmāṃsā requires miraculous authentication of Vedic authorship. D. Yoga treats *siddhis* as obstacles to *samādhi*, and Buddhism prefers the "miracle of instruction" to displays of power.

Answer: D.

Indian sources often acknowledge extraordinary powers while declining to use them as the central authentication of revelation. This is a contrast, not a forced parallel.

33. Which set gives the most defensible cumulative test for a revelation-claim?

A. Internal coherence, credible testimony, moral fruits, experiential grounding and responsiveness to defeaters. B. Institutional antiquity alone. C. Emotional intensity plus numerical popularity. D. Scriptural self-certification without external checks.

Answer: A.

No single criterion proves divine origin. Convergence offers defeasible warrant while preserving the possibility of criticism and comparison.

34. The strongest epistemic force of competing revelations is that they:

A. Prove that no religious experience ever occurs. B. function as a diversity defeater against automatic certainty and require comparative assessment. C. establish one neutral universal scripture. D. eliminate the distinction between truth and justification.

Answer: B.

Incompatible well-formed traditions make community-internal warrant insufficient by itself. Diversity complicates justification without automatically refuting every local claim.

35. Which statement correctly distinguishes revelation, inspiration and infallibility?

A. All three mean that every scriptural sentence was dictated verbatim. B. Revelation concerns freedom from error; infallibility concerns encounter. C. Revelation is disclosure, inspiration concerns divine-human mediation, and infallibility concerns freedom from error. D. Inspiration is identical with natural theology.

Answer: C.

The concepts answer different questions: what is disclosed, how it is mediated, and whether error is excluded. Conflating them produces an imprecise account of scripture.

36. Which formulation best resolves whether faith is indispensable for revelation?

A. Faith creates the objective divine act. B. Revelation is impossible unless every observer accepts it. C. Faith is irrelevant once information is communicated. D. Faith is indispensable to recognition and existential reception, though not necessarily to the objective occurrence of disclosure.

Answer: D.

The distinction preserves both realism and appropriation. Hick highlights reception; the propositional realist reminds us that truth is not manufactured by belief.

37. Aquinas' distinction between *fides quae creditur* and *fides qua creditur* is the distinction between:

A. The content believed and the act or disposition by which one believes. B. Natural science and revealed theology. C. Demonstration and sensory perception. D. Creator and creation.

Answer: A.

The pair prevents faith from being reduced either to doctrine alone or to contentless trust. Faith has both an objective and a subjective pole.

38. Which claim wrongly makes reason constitutive rather than regulative?

A. Reason may expose internal contradiction in a doctrine. B. Reason alone must generate every legitimate religious content, including mysteries. C. Reason can compare testimonial credibility. D. Reason may guide the interpretation of scripture.

Answer: B.

The constitutive claim turns rationalism into the sole source of religion. A regulative account gives reason real authority without requiring it to produce revelation.

39. In the debate between public testimony and private revelation, the best moderate position is that:

A. Private disclosure is infallible for everyone. B. Public testimony converts revelation into demonstration. C. Revelation-warrant may be cumulative and defeasible, combining first-person experience with communal and historical checks. D. Competing revelations cancel every possible claim immediately.

Answer: C.

Private experience provides immediacy but limited public reach; testimony provides transmissibility but introduces reliability problems. A cumulative account recognises both.

40. A defensible moderate form of doxastic voluntarism claims that:

A. One can instantly choose any proposition as true. B. The will is irrelevant to faith because all belief is mechanically caused. C. Desire makes a proposition true. D. The will can indirectly shape attention, trust, practices and consent where evidence is non-coercive.

Answer: D.

This is compatible with Aquinas' account of intellect and will. It avoids the implausible claim that a person can simply command arbitrary belief into existence.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8

41. A student writes, "Faith is belief without any evidence." Which correction is best?

A. Faith is trustful commitment beyond conclusive proof, often supported by grounds, and need not oppose evidence. B. Faith is demonstrative knowledge and therefore stronger than reason. C. Faith has no cognitive content whatsoever. D. Faith is irrational by definition but useful in practice.

Answer: A.

The error conflates non-demonstrative assent with groundlessness. Faith may be rationally supported, supra-rational in commitment, and still answerable to defeaters.

42. Which sentence correctly states Aquinas' position on conflict between reason and faith?

A. Faith may require acceptance of a logical contradiction. B. Genuine reason and genuine revelation cannot conflict; apparent conflict indicates defective reasoning or interpretation. C. Reason is unnecessary once scripture is available. D. Every revealed mystery can eventually be demonstrated.

Answer: B.

Aquinas allows mysteries to exceed reason, not contradict it. This distinction separates supra-rationality from irrationality.

43. Which is the precise correction to "For Mīmāṃsā, the Veda is God's revealed speech"?

A. Mīmāṃsā rejects Vedic authority. B. Mīmāṃsā accepts only a human author of the Veda. C. Mīmāṃsā treats the Veda as *apauruṣeya*, authorless rather than the speech of a creator God. D. Mīmāṃsā derives the Veda through Nyāya inference.

Answer: C.

Mīmāṃsā offers scriptural authority without a personal revealer. Calling it creator-speech destroys the very point of the comparison.

44. Which correction should be made to "Hume proved miracles impossible"?

A. Hume accepted every well-intentioned report. B. Hume addressed only the morality of witnesses. C. Hume defined miracles as ordinary coincidences. D. Hume argued mainly that testimony normally cannot overcome the strong evidence supporting natural regularities.

Answer: D.

Hume raises an evidential bar; he does not deduce the metaphysical impossibility of divine action. Swinburne and Earman challenge the strength of that bar.

45. Which condition prevents James's "will to believe" from becoming a licence for wishful thinking?

A. The option must be living, forced and momentous, and evidence must be genuinely inconclusive. B. The belief must be comforting. C. A religious authority must command it. D. The option must be scientifically falsified.

Answer: A.

James permits passional decision only in tightly bounded cases. Evidence still controls wherever it is sufficiently decisive.

46. Which correction should be made to "Plantinga says God's existence is self-evident"?

A. Plantinga says it is analytically true. B. Plantinga says theistic belief can be properly basic - grounded without inference, warranted under suitable conditions and defeasible. C. Plantinga says it follows from Hume's miracle argument. D. Plantinga rejects all cognitive faculties except perception.

Answer: B.

Proper basicity does not mean self-evidence. It concerns a belief's rational status when produced and grounded in the right way.

47. A science-religion answer consists only of Galileo and Darwin. What is the best correction?

A. Replace both with a list of modern technologies. B. Defend the Draper-White warfare thesis as universally accepted. C. Organise the answer through conflict, independence, dialogue and integration, then evaluate their costs. D. Claim science and religion have never interacted.

Answer: C.

Historical episodes may illustrate a model but cannot substitute for philosophical classification. Barbour's typology directly answers the relation demanded.

48. Which formulation avoids the common rational/irrational binary trap?

A. All faith is rational because believers are sincere. B. All faith is irrational because it exceeds proof. C. Only demonstrable propositions can rationally guide action. D. Faith may be rationally grounded, supra-rational in commitment, or irrational when it contradicts reason and rejects all correction.

Answer: D.

The middle category is essential. Supra-rational commitment goes beyond coercive evidence while remaining coherent, ethically answerable and defeasible.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 11 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

The answers below are independently prepared practice models, not official UPSC model answers.

PYQ 1 - 2019, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact verified question: What is instrumental to self-revelation: Faith or Reason? Justify your position.

Demand decoding: Choose the more decisive instrument rather than merely saying that both matter. Explain what self-revelation means, distinguish reception from critical assessment, and justify a graded position.

Model solution: Self-revelation is divine self-disclosure: the manifestation of the transcendent to a human subject.

Faith is its primary instrument of reception, while reason is its indispensable regulative instrument. Revelation is not merely an externally observable event; it becomes revelation *for* a person when the event is recognised, trusted and appropriated as disclosure.

John Hick's non-propositional account clarifies this priority. Historical events are religiously ambiguous and become revelatory through an "experiencing-as" structure: faith perceives an occurrence as divine action. Without such receptive faith, the same occurrence remains only a secular event. Kierkegaard likewise stresses passionate inward appropriation under objective uncertainty. Revelation concerns an existential relation, not merely an inference.

Yet faith cannot be equated with arbitrary credulity. Aquinas treats faith as firm intellectual assent to divine truth, commanded by the will and supported by motives of credibility. Reason tests coherence, rejects contradiction, assesses testimony and distinguishes authentic disclosure from delusion or manipulation. In Advaita, *śraddhā* enables receptivity to *śruti*, but *manana* removes doubts; trust initiates inquiry rather than abolishing it.

The strongest objection is that a propositional revelation, if objectively communicated by God, remains true whether or not anyone believes it. This is correct regarding the **objective occurrence or content** of disclosure. However, unreceived information does not become revelation in the subject's religious life. Faith is therefore indispensable to revelation's recognition and efficacy, though not necessarily to its objective existence.

Thus faith is more instrumental to self-revelation because it receives and appropriates disclosure; reason remains regulative, preventing reception from degenerating into irrationalism.

Why this earns marks:

- Makes the required choice and qualifies it.
- Uses Hick, Aquinas, Kierkegaard and *śraddhā-manana* analytically.
- Distinguishes objective disclosure from subjective reception.
- Ends with a directive-responsive verdict.

PYQ 2 - 2020, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the significance of 'Religion' vis-à-vis the present scientific and technological development.

Demand decoding: Model the science-religion relation rather than narrating famous conflicts. Explain religion's continuing significance, acknowledge genuine tensions, and state a defensible contemporary relationship.

Model solution: Scientific and technological development has transformed explanatory power and human agency, but it has not made religion simply redundant. The relation is best assessed through Ian Barbour's four models.

Conflict arises when scientific materialism claims that only scientifically certified entities are real, or when scriptural literalism makes empirically testable claims contrary to established science. The nineteenth-century Draper-White "warfare thesis", however, is rejected by most historians as an oversimplification. **Independence**, represented by Stephen Jay Gould's NOMA, assigns empirical facts to science and ultimate meaning and value to religion. It avoids conflict but does so by preventing either domain from making claims relevant to the other.

Dialogue allows interaction at boundary questions: why there is an intelligible universe, how models and metaphors mediate knowledge, and what ethical limits should govern technology. **Integration** attempts stronger syntheses through natural theology, theology of nature or process thought, though it risks tying theology to provisional scientific theories.

Religion remains significant in at least three respects. First, technology determines what humans *can* do but not what they *ought* to do; questions concerning artificial intelligence, biotechnology and ecological responsibility require normative reasoning. Second, religion addresses existential orientation, suffering, hope and community. Third, religious traditions can motivate moral transformation, though they must remain open to scientific correction where they make empirical claims.

Indian thought offers similar resources. Vivekananda presented Vedānta as experience-oriented and science-compatible, while the classical debate over whether *śabda* is an independent *pramāṇa* asks whether testimony can disclose what perception and inference cannot.

Hence neither wholesale conflict nor sealed independence is adequate. Religion remains significant through ethical orientation and boundary dialogue, with local conflict wherever a religious assertion becomes genuinely empirical.

Why this earns marks:

- Uses Barbour's full typology and evaluates each model.
- Corrects the warfare-thesis and NOMA traps.
- Connects religion to technology without vague moralising.
- Adds a relevant Indian epistemological comparison and a graded verdict.

PYQ 3 - 2020, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: What are the basic tenets of faith? Distinguish between faith and belief.

Demand decoding: The stem has two separate tasks: enumerate the constitutive tenets of faith, then distinguish faith from belief through precise axes. A good answer must not define faith as mere belief without evidence.

Model solution: Faith is a fiduciary and volitional relation to what is held ultimate: it includes cognitive assent but adds trust, commitment and a way of life. Belief, by contrast, is primarily propositional assent - believing *that* something is the case. Therefore every developed faith includes beliefs, but every belief is not faith.

The basic tenets of faith are:

1. **An ultimate object:** God, Brahman, Dharma or another transcendent focus is treated as finally significant.
2. **Assent:** faith contains some intelligible content; it is never contentless feeling.
3. **Trust beyond coercive proof:** the evidence may support commitment without compelling it.
4. **Volitional commitment:** the person entrusts life and action, accepting existential risk.
5. **Hope:** faith anticipates a good not yet secured.
6. **Communal mediation:** tradition, testimony, worship and practice transmit and discipline faith.
7. **Transformative fruits:** fidelity, conduct and character test whether professed faith has existential reality.

Faith and belief differ on several axes. Their **objects** differ: belief ordinarily concerns a proposition, whereas faith may concern a person or ultimate reality. Their **grammar** differs: one believes *that* a proposition is true but believes *in* or trusts an object. Their **mode** differs: belief is cognitive assent; faith is assent plus entrusting and commitment. Belief is largely involuntary - one cannot simply decide that it is raining - whereas faith involves will-governed attention, consent and practice. Finally, belief fails through falsehood, while faith can fail through betrayal, infidelity or idolatrous commitment.

Aquinas expresses the distinction through *fides quae creditur*, the content believed, and *fides qua creditur*, the act or disposition by which one believes. Wilfred Cantwell Smith similarly resists reducing faith to modern propositional belief; Tillich calls faith ultimate concern, and Buber's I-Thou relation shows why relational commitment cannot be exhausted by I-It propositions.

Indian traditions deepen the point. The *Gītā* 17.2-3 treats *śraddhā* as constitutive of character and grades it as *sāttvika*, *rājasa* or *tāmasa*. Buddhist *saddhā* is provisional trust directed toward verification, not blind assent.

A practical test is whether the two can come apart. A person may affirm every proposition of a creed yet refuse trust, obedience or self-commitment: belief exists without living faith. Conversely, a person may exhibit deep fidelity and trust while being unable to formulate an elaborate doctrine. This shows why faith cannot be reduced to the quantity or precision of beliefs held.

A reductionist may argue that "believing in" simply means believing that an object exists and is trustworthy. But one may believe that a person is reliable while refusing to entrust anything to that person. The performative commitment remains irreducible.

Thus faith is not a weaker species of belief. Belief supplies faith's cognitive content; faith transforms that content into trust, fidelity and existential orientation.

Why this earns marks:

- Answers both printed tasks in the required order.
- Enumerates seven tenets and distinguishes five clear axes.
- Uses *fides qua/fides quae*, Smith, Tillich, Buber and Indian parity purposefully.
- Includes a serious reductionist objection and reply.

PYQ 4 - 2021, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the role of reason and faith in religion. Can reason be a regulative force in the formulation of religious beliefs? Explain.

Demand decoding: Map both reason and faith, then answer the precise second question. The key distinction is between reason as **regulative** - constraining and assessing belief - and reason as **constitutive** - independently

generating religious content.

Model solution: Reason and faith are neither simple rivals nor interchangeable sources. **Reason can and should regulate religious belief, but it is not always constitutive of its distinctive content.** It can establish probabilities, expose contradiction and discipline interpretation; revelation and faith may supply claims and commitments that unaided reason does not generate.

Reason performs four religious functions. First, it constructs **natural theology** from publicly accessible premises, as in Aquinas' arguments for the preambles of faith and Nyāya inference to Īśvara. Second, it tests logical coherence: no appeal to mystery can make a contradiction true. Third, it interprets scripture, distinguishing literal, analogical and historically conditioned meaning. Fourth, it assesses testimony, experience and consequences, thereby checking fanaticism and apologetic excess.

Faith performs a different function. It is not mere assent without evidence but trustful commitment to an ultimate object. In Aquinas, faith is an act of the intellect assenting to revealed truth under the command of the will moved by grace. It has the firmness of knowledge without demonstrative vision. Kierkegaard instead emphasises passionate inward commitment under objective uncertainty: proof cannot substitute for existential appropriation. The Augustinian-Anselmian tradition of faith seeking understanding mediates these poles - faith begins inquiry, while understanding deepens faith.

Their interaction appears clearly in revelation. The **propositional model** regards revelation as divinely communicated truths; reason judges their coherence and the credibility of testimony but does not derive mysteries such as Trinity. Hick's **non-propositional model** treats revelation as divine action or encounter interpreted through faith. Here reason compares interpretations, while faith supplies the "experiencing-as" through which an ambiguous event is received as disclosure.

Reason is therefore **regulative** in at least four senses. It may veto contradictions, demand conceptual clarity, compare evidence and rival revelations, and assess moral fruits. It is not necessarily **constitutive**, because it does not by itself create the object of trust, the content of an alleged revelation or the lived commitment of faith. Kant's restriction of speculative reason reinforces this modest role, though it does not establish fideism.

The Indian traditions provide a close parallel. Mīmāṃsā and Nyāya accept *śabda* as a source distinct from perception and inference, while Cārvāka refuses supersensible testimony. In Advaita, *śruti* discloses Brahman; *śraddhā* enables hearing, and *manana* uses reason to remove doubt. *Tarka* is auxiliary rather than an independent generator of supersensible truth. Thus reason regulates reception without replacing testimony.

Contemporary religious epistemology further clarifies this regulating role. Plantinga's proper basicity denies that every rational belief must be inferred, but it does not abolish reason: basic theistic belief remains defeasible by evil, projection and religious diversity. Alston's doxastic-practice approach likewise permits rational participation while leaving room for comparison and criticism. Reason may therefore operate before assent by testing grounds, during assent by maintaining coherence, and after assent by answering defeaters. Its work is continuous even when it is not the original source of belief.

Two objections arise. **Fideism** argues that rational regulation domesticates revelation and makes faith answerable to alien standards. Yet faith insulated from non-contradiction and ethical criticism can licence fanaticism. Conversely, **evidentialism**, represented by Clifford, demands proportioned evidence for every belief. William James replies that living, forced and momentous options may rationally require commitment when evidence is genuinely inconclusive; this permits decision beyond proof, not against evidence.

The strongest synthesis is Aquinas' two-level account: reason establishes preambles and rules out contradiction; revelation presents mysteries; faith assents where evidence is non-coercive. Its weakness is the disputed credibility of revelation, especially amid competing traditions. Hence rational regulation must remain public, defeasible and comparative.

In conclusion, reason is a necessary regulative force in religion: it disciplines belief, interpretation and testimony. It is not the sole constitutive source of religion, because faith contributes trust and revelation claims disclosure. Rational religion therefore means faith going beyond demonstration while never claiming a right to go against reason.

Why this earns marks:

- Answers the regulative-force clause explicitly and repeatedly.

- Integrates natural theology, revelation models and multiple relation-types.
- Uses Aquinas, Kierkegaard, Kant, Clifford, James and Indian *pramāṇa* material analytically.
- Handles both fideist and evidentialist objections before a graded synthesis.

PYQ 5 - 2022, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Is the notion of faith indispensable for the idea of revelation? Critically comment.

Demand decoding: Give a short evaluative answer. Distinguish an objective act or content of disclosure from its subjective recognition and religious efficacy.

Model solution: Revelation means divine self-disclosure, whereas faith is the trusting reception of and commitment to that disclosure. **Faith is indispensable to revelation as apprehended and lived, though not necessarily to the objective occurrence or truth of an alleged disclosure.**

On John Hick's non-propositional view, revelation primarily occurs through divine action, encounter or historical event; propositions are later human interpretations. Events are religiously ambiguous. The same occurrence can receive a secular causal description or be "experienced as" providential. Faith is therefore constitutive of recognition: without it, an event is not revelation *for* the subject. Kierkegaard's emphasis on subjective appropriation similarly shows that detached observation cannot replace existential reception.

The claim also applies partly to propositional revelation. A divinely communicated proposition may be true independently of the hearer's response, but it becomes religiously operative only when trusted and obeyed. Aquinas' distinction between the revealed object and the act of faith supports this: *fides quae* names content, while *fides qua* names the believing disposition.

The strongest objection is realist. If God actually discloses a truth, disbelief cannot cancel that act; otherwise revelation becomes projection by the believer. This objection correctly preserves revelation's objective pole. Faith should therefore not be called the creator of revelation. It is the condition of its acknowledgement and efficacy. Reason must still test coherence, testimony and moral fruit, since uncritical faith can misrecognise fantasy as disclosure.

Indian *śraddhā* illustrates this mediated position: trust makes receptivity to *śruti* possible, while *manana* disciplines understanding. Accordingly, faith is indispensable subjectively and existentially, but objective revelation, if real, is not produced by faith.

Why this earns marks:

- Makes the crucial objective/subjective distinction.
- Uses both propositional and non-propositional models.
- Avoids making faith either dispensable or reality-creating.
- Supplies an Indian parallel and a critical verdict.

PYQ 6 - 2023, Q5(b), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Can religious beliefs be justified? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Identify the standard of justification rather than trying to prove God's existence. Contrast evidentialism with proper basicity, test both, and give a qualified answer.

Model solution: Religious beliefs can be justified, but their justification need not always take the form of inference from neutral evidence. The dispute is between **evidentialism** and forms of **proper basicity**.

Locke and W. K. Clifford require assent to be proportioned to evidence; Clifford's shipowner shows that irresponsible belief can harm others. On this view, religious belief requires argument, testimony or experience strong enough to support it. Antony Flew's presumption of atheism similarly places the initial burden on the theist. The strength of this approach is public accountability; its weakness is an over-narrow foundation that may also threaten ordinary beliefs about memory, other minds and the past.

William James permits commitment where an option is living, forced and momentous and the evidence genuinely inconclusive. This does not licence belief against evidence. Alvin Plantinga goes further: belief in God may be **properly basic** - grounded in appropriate experience without being inferred. Classical foundationalism is too narrow and self-referentially unstable. Such belief is not self-evident or immune to criticism; it remains defeasible by evil,

projection or religious diversity. The Great Pumpkin objection asks why any fantasy cannot then become basic. Plantinga replies that proper basicity requires appropriate grounding, proper cognitive function and responsiveness to defeaters, not whim.

Indian epistemology offers an exact comparison. Mīmāṃsā's *svataḥ-prāmāṇya* treats cognition as valid until defeated, approximating proper basicity; Nyāya's *parataḥ-prāmāṇya* makes validity depend on further certification, approximating evidentialism.

Thus religious beliefs may be justified through evidence, experience, testimony or disciplined basic trust. However, incompatible religious practices create a serious diversity defeater. Justification is possible and defeasible, not automatic or universally compelling.

Why this earns marks:

- Names the epistemological issue immediately.
- Balances Clifford, James and Plantinga accurately.
- Handles the Great Pumpkin and diversity objections.
- Uses the precise *svataḥ/parataḥ-prāmāṇya* comparison.

PYQ 7 - 2023, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the rational and irrational aspects of faith in the discourse of religion.

Demand decoding: Do not force a binary. Distinguish the rational, **supra-rational** and genuinely irrational, show how each appears in faith, and explain criteria separating legitimate transcendence from arbitrariness.

Model solution: Faith has a rational dimension and a dimension that exceeds demonstrative reason; it becomes irrational only when it contradicts reason or insulates itself from every possible correction. The decisive distinction is therefore **rational / supra-rational / irrational**.

Faith is rational in several respects. It possesses cognitive content, appeals to testimony and experience, seeks internal coherence, and produces reasons for trust. Natural theology provides arguments for the existence or attributes of God; apologetics examines historical testimony; reason interprets scripture and compares rival claims. Aquinas' account is paradigmatic: faith is an act of intellect assenting firmly to revealed truth under the command of will. Reason establishes the preambles of faith and shows that mysteries do not contradict them. Motives of credibility render assent responsible without converting it into demonstration.

Faith is **supra-rational** when it goes beyond what reason can conclusively prove but does not violate logical or moral constraints. Kierkegaard's passionate inwardness under objective uncertainty captures the existential risk of commitment, although his Abrahamic example can appear perilously close to suspending universal ethics. William James offers a more restricted formulation: a living, forced and momentous option may be decided by the passionate nature only when evidence is genuinely inconclusive. In Advaita, *śraddhā* enables receptive inquiry into what perception and inference cannot independently disclose, while *manana* removes doubts. Thus trust initiates verification.

Faith becomes irrational when it assents against decisive evidence, embraces contradiction, refuses every defeater, or uses alleged revelation to legitimise cruelty. Extreme fideism risks making arbitrary commitment a virtue. Competing revelations intensify the problem: if incompatible claims are each insulated by faith, no critical adjudication remains.

Reason can nonetheless overreach. Cliffordian evidentialism, if interpreted as requiring inference for every rational belief, excludes memory, other minds and much testimonial knowledge. Plantinga therefore argues that belief in God may be properly basic - grounded, warranted and defeasible rather than inferred. The Great Pumpkin objection correctly demands constraints; Plantinga invokes appropriate circumstances, proper function and defeater-responsiveness, though religious diversity remains difficult.

Indian debates display the same range. Cārvāka's restriction to perception approaches a strict rationalist limit; Nyāya accepts inference and reliable testimony; Mīmāṃsā recognises *apauruṣeya śabda* without treating it as the speech of a creator God. Their disagreement concerns the extent, not the abandonment, of rational warrant.

Therefore the non-demonstrative character of faith is not itself irrational. Faith is rational when grounded and coherent, supra-rational when responsibly committed beyond coercive proof, and irrational only when it contradicts evidence,

morality or reason while denying all correction.

Why this earns marks:

- Supplies the crucial threefold distinction.
- Explains rational grounds, existential excess and genuine irrationality separately.
- Uses Aquinas, Kierkegaard, James, Plantinga and Indian schools as arguments.
- Gives operational criteria for identifying fanaticism.

PYQ 8 - 2024, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the role of reason in religion.

Demand decoding: Present the constructive, critical and interpretive roles of reason, then define its limits. Avoid either rationalism or fideism as an unqualified conclusion.

Model solution: Reason plays a constructive and critical role in religion, although it need not be the sole source of religious truth. Its most defensible status is **regulative rather than universally constitutive**.

First, reason constructs **natural theology** by arguing from publicly accessible premises. Aquinas' preambles of faith and Nyāya inference to Īśvara exemplify this role. Second, it tests coherence: doctrines cannot claim exemption from non-contradiction merely by being called mysteries. Third, reason interprets scripture, adjudicating literal, symbolic and context-sensitive readings. Fourth, it evaluates testimony and religious experience through credibility, consistency and comparison with alternative explanations. Fifth, it performs an ethical check: a revelation-claim producing cruelty cannot demand immunity from moral scrutiny.

Reason also clarifies distinctions central to religion - knowledge and faith, natural and revealed theology, proposition and encounter, evidence and commitment. It thereby prevents faith from collapsing into superstition or fanaticism. In Advaita, *manana* removes doubts arising after the reception of *śruti*; *tarka* remains an auxiliary discipline rather than an independent source of Brahman-knowledge.

Yet reason has limits. Kant denies that speculative reason can straightforwardly know supersensible objects. Aquinas holds that reason can establish some preambles but not mysteries such as Trinity. Kierkegaard adds that objective proof cannot replace subjective appropriation. These limits make room for supra-rational faith, not for contradiction.

Fideism objects that rational criticism subordinates divine disclosure to human standards. But an alleged revelation wholly insulated from coherence, evidence and ethical fruit becomes indistinguishable from delusion. Conversely, strict evidentialism overstates reason's inferential reach.

Thus reason constructs, interprets, criticises and regulates religious belief. It may not generate every content of revelation or every act of trust, but religion without rational discipline loses its claim to responsible assent.

Why this earns marks:

- Organises reason's role into distinct functions.
- Explains regulative versus constitutive reason.
- States limits without turning them into irrationalism.
- Integrates Aquinas, Kant and an Indian parallel.

PYQ 9 - 2024, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question: What kind of epistemic justifications are possible with regard to claims to revelation? Discuss with your own comments.

Demand decoding: Offer a typology of possible warrant, identify the special difficulties of revelation, and rank the criteria in an explicit personal assessment. No single criterion should be presented as conclusive.

Model solution: A claim to revelation asserts that a truth, event or encounter discloses the transcendent. Such a claim cannot be justified merely by repeating that it is revealed. Its warrant, if any, must be **cumulative, defeasible and comparative**.

First, **propositional coherence** matters. A revealed doctrine should be internally consistent and compatible with secure knowledge unless it offers strong reasons for revision. Coherence cannot prove divine origin, but contradiction is a decisive defeater. Second, **testimony and transmission** may justify belief when recipients and communities are

credible, independent strands converge, and the chain of preservation is reliable. Yet testimony remains vulnerable to error, legend and institutional interest.

Third, **religious experience** can provide first-person or community-grounded warrant. Hick's non-propositional model treats revelation as divine self-disclosure in an event "experienced as" religiously significant. William Alston compares such experiential belief to socially established doxastic practices. Its limitation is privacy and conceptual dependence: different traditions interpret experience incompatibly.

Fourth, **moral and transformative fruits** supply pragmatic confirmation. Enduring compassion, integrity and liberation count in favour of a claim; cruelty and manipulation count strongly against it. Fruits test authenticity but cannot alone establish truth, since useful beliefs may be false. Fifth, **historical signs or miracles** may be cited. Hume shows that testimony to a violation of nature bears an unusually heavy burden, although Swinburne's recasting of miracle as a non-repeatable counter-instance prevents impossibility from being built into the definition.

Sixth, **proper basicity** may justify reception without inference. Plantinga argues that theistic belief formed in appropriate circumstances can be grounded, warranted and defeasible. The Great Pumpkin and religious-diversity objections, however, require disciplined conditions and active engagement with defeaters.

Indian epistemology sharpens the issue. Nyāya treats reliable *āpta-vākya* as testimony requiring extrinsic certification; Mīmāṃsā regards the Veda as *apauruṣeya* and cognition as valid until defeated. The latter is not revelation by a personal creator. Advaita combines *śruti*, *śraddhā*, *manana* and experiential assimilation, making reason and practice checks on reception.

Competing revelations are the strongest objection: internally coherent communities may support incompatible disclosures. Appeals to a shared scripture are circular, while neutral criteria may already privilege one tradition. The best reply is modest: diversity defeats claims of automatic certainty but not every local warrant. It demands comparative assessment of coherence, testimony, ethical fruit, experience and defeaters.

In my view, no isolated miracle, private experience or institutional assertion is sufficient. A revelation-claim is justified only by convergence among rational coherence, credible transmission, transformative fruit and experience, with openness to revision. Such warrant may rationally guide a community without becoming coercive proof for all.

Why this earns marks:

- Provides a clear six-part typology of justification.
- Evaluates each criterion rather than listing it.
- Uses revelation models, miracle debate, Plantinga and Indian epistemology.
- Gives the requested personal comment as a ranked, defeasible verdict.

PYQ 10 - 2025, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact verified question: How does Aquinas' account of Faith as "an intellectual assent" reconcile the juxtaposition between Reason and Faith? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Explain the Thomist mechanism of reconciliation: intellect, will and grace; knowledge, opinion and faith; preambles and mysteries. Contrast it briefly with the two extremes.

Model solution: Aquinas reconciles reason and faith by locating both within the intellect while distinguishing their grounds and objects. **Faith is an act of the intellect assenting to divine truth under the command of the will moved by grace.** It is therefore neither irrational feeling nor demonstrative knowledge.

Faith occupies a mean between knowledge and opinion. Knowledge has demonstrative evidence or vision; opinion lacks firmness and retains fear of error. Faith concerns what is unseen and not rationally demonstrated, yet it gives firm assent because its formal ground is divine testimony. The will does not make truth arbitrary; it commits the intellect where evidence is non-coercive and where motives of credibility make assent reasonable.

Aquinas' two-storey structure completes the reconciliation. **Reason** can establish the preambles of faith, such as that God exists, and can test doctrine for contradiction. **Revelation** discloses mysteries such as Trinity that exceed unaided reason. Because reason and revelation ultimately derive from the same divine source, genuine findings of reason cannot contradict genuine faith. Apparent conflict indicates faulty argument or faulty interpretation.

This position rejects two extremes. Cliffordian rationalism risks reducing faith to what can already be proved, making revelation redundant. Kierkegaardian fideism preserves existential risk but may weaken public standards of criticism.

Aquinas preserves both rational accountability and supra-rational content.

An objection remains: will-governed assent may appear to be doxastic voluntarism - one cannot choose belief at will. Aquinas' defensible reply is indirect: the will governs attention, trust and consent in conditions where reason does not compel either conclusion; it does not manufacture evidence.

Thus intellectual assent reconciles reason and faith by giving reason a preparatory and regulative role, revelation a supra-rational content, and faith a firm but non-demonstrative mode of appropriation.

Why this earns marks:

- Explains the exact mechanism rather than merely saying "harmony".
- Distinguishes knowledge, opinion and faith.
- Uses preambles/mysteries and intellect/will/grace precisely.
- Tests Aquinas against rationalism, fideism and voluntarism.

PYQ 11 - 2025, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Distinguish between Natural Theology and Revealed Theology in the context of the Propositional view of Revelation.

Demand decoding: This is a three-term demand. Distinguish the two theologies, but do so specifically within the propositional model in which revelation communicates truth-content.

Model solution: Natural theology and revealed theology differ chiefly in **source, method and accessible content**. Within the **propositional view of revelation**, the distinction is especially sharp because revelation is understood as divinely authorised truths communicated for belief.

Natural theology uses unaided human reason and publicly accessible premises. Its methods include metaphysical argument, inference from causation, order, contingency or morality, and conceptual analysis. Its conclusions are in principle available to any competent reasoner irrespective of special scripture. Aquinas' arguments for God's existence are "preambles of faith": they may establish that God exists and possesses certain attributes, though they cannot disclose specifically revealed mysteries. Nyāya's inference to Īśvara is a useful Indian analogue of rational theology, though it arises within a different doctrinal setting.

Revealed theology begins from propositions accepted as divinely disclosed through prophets, scripture or authoritative tradition. It systematises and interprets truths that reason could not discover, or could not know securely and universally, by itself. In Aquinas, doctrines such as Trinity and Incarnation are mysteries: they exceed reason without contradicting it. Reason remains active within revealed theology by clarifying terms, drawing implications, resolving apparent inconsistencies and defending credibility.

The propositional model therefore presents a structured sequence:

1. God communicates truth-content.
2. Prophetic or scriptural testimony mediates it.
3. Faith assents to it as divine testimony.
4. Theology organises the propositions into doctrine.

This model differs from Hick's non-propositional account, where revelation is primarily divine action or self-presence and propositions are human interpretations of encounter. The comparison shows that natural/revealed theology is not identical with reason/irrationality: both are intellectual enterprises, but they begin from different epistemic sources.

The contrast may therefore be summarised along four axes: natural theology begins from common experience, uses inference, seeks publicly discussable conclusions and normally reaches limited truths; revealed theology begins from accepted disclosure, uses faith-informed interpretation, addresses a believing community and includes mysteries unavailable to unaided inquiry.

Two problems arise. First, a propositional revelation may be authenticated circularly: scripture validates the community and the community validates scripture. Second, rival scriptures advance incompatible propositions. Defenders therefore appeal cumulatively to coherence, testimony, historical context, moral fruits and experience rather than to bare self-certification.

Indian comparison requires care. Mīmāṃsā accepts the *apauruṣeya* Veda as an independent *śabda-pramāṇa*, but not as propositions spoken by a creator God. It resembles revealed theology in disclosing supersensible dharma, yet differs from creator-centred divine communication. Advaita further joins *śruti* with *manana* and *nididhyāsana*.

Hence natural theology reasons toward truths available without special disclosure; revealed theology reasons from divinely disclosed propositions. Their distinction concerns epistemic starting point, not the presence versus absence of reason. A defensible propositional model makes revelation supra-rational and reason-governed, never anti-rational.

Why this earns marks:

- Treats the propositional context as central, not decorative.
- Distinguishes source, method, content and accessibility.
- Adds Hick as the precise rival model.
- Uses Indian parity without misclassifying *apauruṣeya* Veda as creator-speech.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE - 6 MODELS

ORIGINAL 1 - 10 marks

Question: "Supra-rational faith need not be irrational." Explain, and state the conditions under which this defence succeeds.

Demand decoding: Define all three categories, defend supra-rationality, and specify safeguards that prevent it from becoming disguised fideism.

Model solution: The supra-rational is what exceeds demonstrative proof; the irrational is what contradicts reason, decisive evidence or moral criticism. **Faith may be supra-rational without being irrational when commitment outruns coercive evidence but remains grounded, coherent and defeasible.**

Aquinas supplies the basic model. Reason can establish preambles and motives of credibility, while revealed mysteries are not demonstrable. Faith is firm intellectual assent under the command of will: it goes beyond proof, yet cannot contradict truth reached by reason. William James provides a secular epistemic limit. Passional commitment is legitimate only when an option is living, forced and momentous and evidence is genuinely inconclusive; his argument does not authorise belief against evidence.

Kierkegaard's objective uncertainty shows why existential relation cannot be replaced by detached proof. Yet his Abrahamic case exposes the danger: if "paradox" suspends every ethical check, supra-rationality becomes irrational immunity. Indian *śraddhā* offers a corrective. In Advaita, trust enables *śravaṇa*, but *manana* removes doubt and *nididhyāsana* directs understanding toward assimilation. Buddhist *saddhā* is similarly verification-directed.

The defence therefore succeeds under four conditions: the faith-claim is internally coherent; it does not contradict secure evidence; it remains answerable to moral fruits; and it admits possible defeaters. Competing revelations must also be compared rather than insulated.

The objection that any non-evidential commitment is arbitrary confuses absence of demonstration with absence of grounds. Testimony, experience and cumulative coherence may rationally support a commitment without compelling it.

Thus supra-rational faith is defensible as responsible trust under uncertainty. It becomes irrational when "beyond reason" is used to mean "against reason" or "immune to correction."

Why this earns marks:

- Defines the decisive threefold distinction.
- Uses Aquinas, James, Kierkegaard and *śraddhā* to build one argument.
- States clear success-conditions and a direct verdict.

ORIGINAL 2 - 10 marks

Question: Is scriptural testimony necessarily a form of revelation by a personal God? Discuss with reference to Mīmāṃsā and theistic models.

Demand decoding: Separate testimonial authority from personal divine speech. Compare rather than assimilate Mīmāṃsā and Abrahamic/theistic propositional revelation.

Model solution: Scriptural testimony need not be conceived as revelation spoken by a personal God. **Theistic propositional models and Mīmāṃsā both grant scripture supersensible authority, but they ground that authority in fundamentally different ways.**

In a creator-centred propositional model, God communicates truth-content through prophets or scripture. The proposition is accepted because divine knowledge and veracity underwrite it; faith receives the testimony, while reason examines coherence and credibility. Aquinas distinguishes truths accessible to natural reason from mysteries known through such revelation.

Mīmāṃsā rejects this author-centred structure. The Veda is *apauruṣeya* - authorless, neither human nor divine composition. Its authority does not depend on proving an omniscient speaker. Vedic *śabda* independently discloses dharma, a supersensible domain unavailable to perception. The absence of an author also removes ordinary defects such as ignorance or deceit.

The similarity is epistemic: both accounts hold that testimony may disclose what perception and inference cannot independently establish. The difference is theological: one relies on a trustworthy personal revealer; the other treats an eternal linguistic tradition as intrinsically authoritative. Therefore calling the Veda "God's revelation" misrepresents Mīmāṃsā.

An objection is that authorless sentences cannot intend or communicate anything. Mīmāṃsā replies by grounding meaning in stable word-meaning relations and an eternal textual tradition, not in a first speaker's intention. Critics may still question how intrinsic authority handles conflicting texts.

Thus scriptural authority and personal revelation overlap but are not identical. Mīmāṃsā proves that a tradition can defend supersensible testimony without positing a divine speaker, though it must meet its own problems of meaning and cross-tradition warrant.

Why this earns marks:

- Preserves the exact *apauruṣeya* distinction.
- Compares source, warrant and content rather than merely listing schools.
- Includes a philosophical objection and a qualified conclusion.

ORIGINAL 3 - 15 marks

Question: Does Hick's non-propositional account make revelation more intelligible at the cost of making it subjective? Critically examine.

Demand decoding: Reconstruct Hick's event/encounter model, explain its advantage over dictated propositions, present the projection and diversity objections, and assess whether his safeguards are adequate.

Model solution: Hick makes revelation more intelligible by treating it as divine self-disclosure in history and experience rather than as a deposit of dictated propositions. **The cost is not outright subjectivism, but a serious dependence on interpretive faith that makes public adjudication difficult.**

The model proceeds in four stages. First, God acts or becomes present in events and encounter. Second, historical events are religiously ambiguous: they can receive both secular and providential descriptions. Third, faith apprehends the event through "experiencing-as." Fourth, communities formulate propositions and doctrines as concept-laden interpretations of the encounter. Revelation is therefore primarily personal and historical; doctrine is secondary articulation.

This account has major strengths. It acknowledges that scripture is mediated through language, culture and community rather than mechanically dictated. It explains doctrinal diversity without necessarily denying an objective divine initiative. It also clarifies why faith is indispensable to reception: an occurrence becomes revelation *for* someone only when recognised and appropriated. The model resembles the difference between encountering a person and listing propositions about that person.

However, the projection objection is powerful. If interpretation constitutes revelatory meaning, how can one distinguish divine disclosure from expectation, political interest or psychological need? Competing religions experience incompatible events as revelatory. Moral transformation is not decisive, because false beliefs may also produce courage or solidarity. Internal coherence is insufficient, because several incompatible systems may each cohere.

Hick can reply that interpretation does not create reality. Experience is concept-laden in ordinary perception as well; this does not make the external world subjective. Revelatory interpretations face the resistance of events, communal memory, rational criticism and moral-spiritual fruits. A cumulative test - coherence, testimony, transformation and comparative explanatory power - can exclude arbitrary projections.

Yet the propositional realist presses a further objection: unless some divine truth-content controls interpretation, the model cannot say what God has actually disclosed. Hick's view may answer that propositions remain indispensable, but as fallible interpretations rather than revelation's primary form. This protects humility while weakening claims to doctrinal infallibility.

Indian comparison supports a mediated account without collapsing into pure subjectivity. Advaita begins with *śruti*, then subjects understanding to *manana* and culminates in assimilative insight through *nididhyāsana*. Trust, conceptual interpretation and transformation interact. Mīmāṃsā, by contrast, gives linguistic testimony a more objective authority and therefore resembles the propositional pole, though without a creator-speaker.

The verdict is graded. Hick successfully explains revelation as encounter, the need for faith and the historical plurality of doctrines. He does not make revelation merely subjective, because he retains an objective divine pole. Nevertheless, his criteria yield defeasible community-relative warrant rather than universal proof. The model is strongest as an account of how revelation is received, weaker as a test of which alleged revelation is true.

Why this earns marks:

- Reconstructs the model before criticising it.
- Separates interpretive mediation from reality-creation.
- Uses projection, diversity and propositional-realist objections with replies.
- Adds an analytically relevant Indian comparison and graded verdict.

ORIGINAL 4 - 15 marks

Question: Does the doctrine of proper basicity solve the problem of religious justification, or merely relocate it? Examine with an Indian epistemological comparison.

Demand decoding: Explain Plantinga's critique of evidentialism and theory of warrant, assess the Great Pumpkin and diversity objections, and use the exact *svataḥ/parataḥ-prāmāṇya* comparison.

Model solution: Proper basicity solves one problem - the claim that religious belief is irrational unless inferred from evidence - but relocates the deeper problem to **grounding, defeaters and religious diversity**.

Classical evidentialism holds that rational beliefs must be self-evident, incorrigible, evident to the senses, or inferred from such foundations. Plantinga argues that this criterion is self-referentially incoherent because it satisfies none of its own conditions. It is also too narrow: beliefs about memory, other minds and the past are ordinarily rational without being inferred from a classical base.

Theistic belief may therefore be **properly basic**. Experiences of guilt, gratitude, wonder or scriptural encounter can ground belief directly rather than function as premises in an argument. In *Warranted Christian Belief*, Plantinga adds that a true belief has warrant when produced by cognitive faculties functioning properly in an appropriate environment according to a truth-aimed design plan. If a *sensus divinitatis* exists and functions properly, belief in God may be warranted.

This answers the *de jure* objection that theistic belief is inherently irrational. It also restores parity with ordinary non-inferential beliefs. Yet the Great Pumpkin objection asks why arbitrary fantasies cannot claim the same status. Plantinga replies that basicity requires appropriate circumstances, grounding and proper function, and remains defeasible. The reply excludes whim but invites a further difficulty: rival religious communities also possess mature practices, experiences and internal criteria.

Religious diversity thus relocates the issue. If incompatible beliefs are basic within different traditions, justification may become community-relative. Evil, projection and cognitive-science explanations can also serve as defeaters. Plantinga does not make belief immune; a believer must answer these challenges. William Alston's doxastic-practice approach similarly secures practical rationality without supplying a neutral proof of reliability.

Indian epistemology makes the structure clearer. Mīmāṃsā's *svataḥ-prāmāṇya* holds that cognition presents itself as valid until defeated; this is the closest analogue of proper basicity. Nyāya's *parataḥ-prāmāṇya* requires validity to be

certified by further cognition and resembles evidentialism. Cārvāka provides the strict limit by refusing supersensible sources. The comparison shows that the dispute is not uniquely Christian; it concerns whether validity is default or earned.

The strongest evidentialist objection is that public accountability is lost. The proper-basicality reply is that accountability shifts from inferential origin to grounding, proper function and response to defeaters. That shift is legitimate but incomplete because no neutral rule decides between mature rival practices.

Therefore proper basicality genuinely defeats the claim that only inferred religious belief can be rational. It does not settle truth or inter-religious conflict. It relocates justification from "Where is the proof?" to "Is the belief properly grounded, undefeated and comparatively responsible?"

Why this earns marks:

- Distinguishes rationality, warrant and truth.
- Reconstructs Plantinga before applying the objections.
- Uses the exact Mīmāṃsā-Nyāya parity.
- Gives a discriminating "solves and relocates" verdict.

ORIGINAL 5 - 20 marks

Question: Can testimony to miracles authenticate a claim to revelation? Evaluate Hume's challenge and its major replies, with an Indian comparison.

Demand decoding: Explain what miracle testimony is supposed to prove, reconstruct both parts of Hume's argument, assess definitional, testimonial and Bayesian replies, and compare the Indian reluctance to use marvels as authentication.

Model solution: Miracles are often offered as public signs that authenticate a prophet, scripture or divine intervention. Yet a miracle report can support revelation only if the event is credible, religiously interpretable and sufficiently connected to the alleged disclosure. **Hume shows that miracle testimony bears an exceptionally heavy burden; his critics show that the burden is not in principle impossible to meet. Even successful testimony would underdetermine a complete revelation.**

In Section X of *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, Hume defines a miracle as a violation of the laws of nature. His Part I argument is an evidential balance. A wise person proportions belief to evidence. Laws of nature rest on uniform experience, whereas testimony rests on the less-than-uniform reliability of human witnesses. The report therefore confronts very strong counter-evidence. Hume's maxim is that no testimony establishes a miracle unless its falsehood would be more miraculous than the reported event; even then, one subtracts the lesser improbability from the greater.

Part II adds four empirical cautions. No miracle, Hume claims, has sufficient attestation from witnesses of exceptional competence and integrity with public reputations at risk. Human beings possess a passion for surprise and wonder. Miracle reports flourish in credulous contexts or descend from them. Finally, contrary miracles offered by rival religions undermine one another because they authenticate incompatible systems. These considerations remain a powerful checklist against fraud, exaggeration and sectarian confirmation bias.

Several replies limit Hume's conclusion. First, the **definitional reply** argues that if a law means an exceptionless regularity, a genuine exception merely shows that the law was misstated; defining miracle as "violation" prejudices the case. Richard Swinburne therefore describes a miracle as a non-repeatable counter-instance to an otherwise well-confirmed law.

Second, Swinburne's principles of credulity and testimony grant apparent experience and report prima facie credibility unless reasons for doubt arise. Hume risks making testimony powerless exactly where it concerns an extraordinary event. Still, extraordinary claims reasonably require stronger controls against dependence, deception and alternative causes.

Third, John Earman's Bayesian criticism distinguishes prior from posterior probability. A very low prior probability can be overcome by multiple sufficiently reliable and independent witnesses. Hume's rhetoric of "uniform experience" does not mathematically prove that no testimonial evidence can cross the threshold. The reply establishes possibility, not that any actual miracle report succeeds.

Fourth, Hume's contrary-miracles argument may overstate cancellation. Rival reports should be assessed individually, and miracles need not support mutually exclusive total systems. Nevertheless, doctrinal underdetermination remains: even if an extraordinary healing occurred, it would not by itself establish which deity acted, why, or whether an entire creed is true.

The circularity objection also matters. To say that experience is uniformly against miracles may presuppose that all miracle reports are false. Hume can answer that "uniform" means the best-established regularity, not a conclusion reached after rejecting every report. His cautious Part II survives more securely than the absolute force often attributed to Part I.

Indian traditions provide a revealing contrast. Patañjali's *Yoga-sūtra* 3.37 treats *siddhis* as obstacles to *samādhi* despite their status as outward accomplishments. In the *Kevaddha Sutta*, the Buddha rejects displays of psychic power as a means of conversion and privileges the transformative "miracle of instruction." Mīmāṃsā grounds Vedic authority in *apauruṣeya* status, not miraculous authentication. These traditions do not uniformly deny extraordinary powers; they question their soteriological and epistemic relevance.

A defender may reply that a miracle's purpose is precisely contextual: an event joined to a morally serious message, prior prediction and durable transformation can form part of a cumulative case. This is stronger than treating marvel alone as proof. Yet the context itself is interpreted through faith, returning the argument to Hick's "experiencing-as" and the problem of competing revelations.

Therefore miracle testimony can at most contribute defeasible evidence to a revelation-claim. Hume rightly imposes rigorous scrutiny but does not establish impossibility. Even when credible testimony makes an extraordinary event probable, authentication requires further argument connecting the event to divine agency and a specific message. Miracles may reinforce faith within an interpretive framework; they rarely compel assent outside it.

Why this earns marks:

- Reconstructs Hume's Part I and Part II distinctly.
- Evaluates Swinburne, Earman, circularity and contrary-miracle replies.
- Separates occurrence, divine agency and doctrinal authentication.
- Uses Indian material as a genuine contrast and reaches a graded verdict.

ORIGINAL 6 - 20 marks

Question: Does revelation require a divine speaker? Compare creator-centred revelation with Mīmāṃsā, Nyāya and Advaita accounts of *śabda* and spiritual knowledge.

Demand decoding: Analyse the conceptual link between revelation and personal agency. Compare Western propositional and encounter models with distinct Indian positions, avoiding the false claim that all authoritative scripture is God's speech.

Model solution: Revelation is commonly defined as divine self-disclosure, which appears to require a personal revealer. Yet Indian theories of *śabda* show that supersensible disclosure can be defended without a creator-speaker.

A divine speaker is necessary for creator-centred propositional revelation, but not for every philosophically defensible model of scriptural or transformative disclosure.

In the propositional theistic model, God communicates truth-content through prophets, scripture or authoritative tradition. Divine omniscience and veracity ground the authority of the propositions. Aquinas distinguishes truths accessible to natural reason from mysteries known through revelation. Faith assents to divine testimony, while reason tests credibility, draws implications and rules out contradiction. This model provides a clear intentional source: someone reveals something to someone.

Its strengths are objectivity and doctrinal determinacy. Revelation does not depend entirely on the recipient's construction; propositions specify what is disclosed. Its problems are equally clear. Human mediation creates questions of inspiration and error. Authentication may be circular, and rival scriptures claim incompatible divine origins. A perfect speaker does not guarantee a perfectly transmitted or interpreted message.

Hick loosens the dependence on speech without abandoning divine agency. In the non-propositional model, God reveals the divine self through acts, presence and encounter. Historical events are experienced as revelatory, while doctrinal propositions are human interpretations. A personal revealer remains, but not necessarily a dictated

sentence. This model handles historical mediation and plurality better, though it increases the projection problem.

Mīmāṃsā offers the strongest challenge to the divine-speaker requirement. The Veda is *apauruṣeya* - authorless and beginningless, neither human composition nor creator-speech. Its authority concerns dharma, which perception cannot disclose. Because there is no author, ordinary defects such as ignorance and deceit do not arise.

Word-meaning relations and the textual tradition carry meaning without dependence on a first speaker's intention. Thus authoritative supersensible testimony is possible without revelation by a person.

The Mīmāṃsā view faces objections. Meaning seems connected to communicative intention; conflicting texts challenge intrinsic authority; and a tradition cannot validate itself merely by declaring authorlessness. Mīmāṃsā responds through linguistic eternality, hermeneutical rules and *svataḥ-prāmāṇya*, according to which cognition is valid until defeated. This secures default authority, though not neutral acceptance across traditions.

Nyāya supplies a contrasting testimonial model. *Śabda* is an independent *pramāṇa* when it is the statement of a reliable speaker, an *āpta*. Here personal competence and sincerity matter. Later Nyāya can connect Vedic authority with Īśvara, but the general epistemology of testimony does not reduce every warranted utterance to revelation. Its *parataḥ-prāmāṇya* demands extrinsic certification, providing stronger public checks than Mīmāṃsā at the cost of regress or dependence on further evidence.

Advaita combines scriptural disclosure, reason and realisation. *Śruti* is indispensable for Brahman, which cannot be objectified through perception or ordinary inference. Yet reception proceeds through *śravaṇa*, *manana* and *nididhyāsana*: hearing the teaching, removing doubt through reasoning, and assimilating insight. *Śraddhā* is disciplined trust that enables inquiry. The authority of *śruti* is not best described as a creator God's verbal intervention; it is a unique means of knowledge whose teaching culminates in direct recognition rather than permanent dependence on propositions.

These positions reveal at least three meanings of "revelation": **personal propositional communication**, **personal self-disclosure in encounter**, and **non-personal scriptural disclosure of a supersensible domain**. If the term is defined strictly as an intentional act of God, Mīmāṃsā cannot count as revelation. If it is used more broadly for authoritative disclosure unavailable to ordinary perception and inference, Mīmāṃsā and Advaita become genuine comparators. Conceptual clarity requires stating which sense is intended.

The theistic objection is that authorless or impersonal disclosure cannot select, intend or guarantee a message. The Indian reply is that epistemic authority need not always derive from a speaker: perception too informs without an intending author, and Mīmāṃsā treats linguistic cognition as independently valid. However, unlike perception, scripture is linguistically and historically transmitted, so hermeneutic and cross-tradition defeaters remain.

Accordingly, revelation does not universally require a divine speaker. It requires one only within a creator-centred intentional definition. A wider epistemology of disclosure can ground authority in authorless *śabda*, reliable testimony or transformative realisation. The cost of widening the term is reduced theological specificity; the gain is a genuinely comparative philosophy of religion that distinguishes disclosure from divine dictation.

Why this earns marks:

- Builds a three-model conceptual map rather than forcing false equivalence.
- Treats Mīmāṃsā, Nyāya and Advaita separately and accurately.
- Includes source, warrant, mediation and defeater analysis.
- Gives a conditional verdict tied to the definition of revelation.